

How AIWA audio aims to give consumers a premium nostalgic trip

In conversation with **Ajay Mehta**, Managing Director at AIWA India, about AIWA's comeback in the country

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When you are putting your hard-earned money into tech, you obviously want to get the best for your dough. Especially with audio products, where the preferences of consumers are so subjective that without experiencing a product in person, it is really difficult to separate the average great from the personal best. You can make educated guesses to a certain extent by conducting market research and surveys, but at the end of the day, it remains a guess. Albeit, one backed by research and statistics, of course. In a country like India, where the consumer base and spectrum of atomised choices is massive, making these guesses becomes more tricky for audio brands.

With AIWA having an impactful presence in the TVs, speakers and head-phones space, I was curious to understand the philosophy of a brand when it enters the Indian market, especially for a foreign brand. In order to get some insight into these areas, I spoke with Mr Ajay Mehta, Managing Director at AIWA India. I picked his brains about AIWA's return to India after a brief hiatus, its perspectives into delighting the end user, the design philosophy of their branded products, and then some. "We are doing the full line of beautiful audio speakers. We are positioned squarely against BOSE, Marshall, and some products of JBL," emphasised Mr Mehta, while commenting on the importance of audio in AIWA's business in India.

Now, when a brand is trying to enter the audio-visual segment, providing



Ajay Mehta
Managing Director, AIWA India

the right experience to the consumers also becomes really important. Because "sound is very subjective," as Mr Mehta rightly mentions. Naturally, this subjectivity (or inherent challenge) also extends to TVs as well. To make sure that AIWA's consumers get the best experience that they can, the brand is rolling out a new initiative called ATP. It is a joint venture between AIWA and its partner stores where, along with offerings from other brands, products from AIWA would also be showcased. However, this will not be a regular showcase. There will be special arrangements made in the stores, which will aid the consumers in making educated choices when buying the brand's speakers and TVs.

As a part of this ATP initiative, store personnel will be trained to ensure that they are able to handle all the queries put forth by the consumers. He further added, "Before Diwali, we hope to finish 100 ATPs across India. I think we

started the program on the 1st of April. Television has also started, and we are almost in all the southern states in terms of our presence."

Brands in India have had experience centres for a while now. Sony has its own line of Sony Centre stores, where they have an expansive collection of products. However, with AIWA going head to head with its competition in a multi-brand store, it will be interesting to see how they fare in this space.

AIWA's speakers have done well in the last few years, with their MI-X330 Bluetooth Speaker also winning our Digit Zero1 Award 2022 for the Best Bluetooth Speaker. And one thing that has stood out in all their speakers is their design language. Multiple speakers in AIWA's portfolio have a retro-themed design. Mr Mehta explained, "You see, because the generation which remembers the AIWA brand, that generation will relate to this kind of design immediately. So if you look at a product like our Enigma, which is a ₹75,000 product, the design of that is a very good combination of retro and modern. It looks retro from afar, but you go close to it and you know, you see the number of controls and the number of cordless mics which connect wirelessly. Then you realise, oh, it's got a lot of tech in it."

But nostalgia isn't the entire strategy behind AIWA's throwback retro design language, as Mr Mehta mentioned that the design of the speakers from the brand also gave them an identity of not being party speakers. This goes to show that the subliminal element of a product's design also holds a lot of importance.

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